Trip Planning Quick Reference

Print, laminate, and keep in your pack.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE

- ☐ Weather: Check forecast for route + destination. Pack for worst conditions.
- ☐ Trail status: Check closures, washouts, snow levels. NPS and WTA are good sources.
- ☐ Trip plan: Leave with emergency contact: route, timeline, vehicle, return time.
- ☐ Ten Essentials: Packed and verified. See our Ten Essentials field card.
- ☐ Phone + power bank: Both at 100%. Offline maps downloaded and tested.
- ☐ Vehicle: Full gas tank, spare tire, tow strap, jumper cables, blanket.
- ☐ Food + water: At least 1 extra meal and 1 extra liter beyond what you plan to use.
- ☐ Clothing: Layers for 20°F colder than forecast. No cotton — wool or synthetic only.

AT THE TRAILHEAD + ON THE TRAIL

- ☐ Sign in at trailhead register. Note where you parked.
- ☐ Confirm turnaround time with your group — commit to it.
- ☐ Stay on marked trails. Off-trail = #1 way people get lost.
- ☐ Check your map regularly, not just when you think you're lost.
- ☐ Drink water and eat snacks regularly. Don't wait until you feel it.
- ☐ Pace to the slowest member. Stay together as a group.
- ☐ If weather deteriorates, head back immediately. Don't push it.

COMMUNICATION + EMERGENCY

- ☐ Emergency contact filed: Name, phone, and your overdue protocol.
- ☐ Overdue plan: 'If I haven't checked in by ___, call 911 with my trip plan.'
- ☐ Cell phone: Try calling 911 even with no signal bars — connects via any carrier.
- ☐ Text 911: If call fails, try texting 911. Uses much less signal than a voice call.
- ☐ Satellite 911 texting: FREE for all carriers via T-Mobile/ Starlink (emergency 911 only). Full messaging: $10/mo.

WHEN YOU RETURN

- ☐ Sign out at trailhead register. Notify your emergency contact you're safe.
- ☐ Report trail hazards to the land manager. Restock your emergency kit.

REMEMBER

The backcountry doesn't care about your schedule. The mountain will be there next weekend. If you filed a trip plan and you're overdue, we start looking along your planned route. Be there when we arrive.

Scan a code or click a label to open the resource.

Trip Plan Form

Satellite 911 Signup